

THE HARMONY OS COLOR SYSTEM IN ACTION

Three categories — Green (Diatonic), Blue (Secondary Dominant), Red (Modal Interchange) — applied to real progressions and real songs.

GREEN

DIATONIC

Naturally in the key. Seven chords from the major scale. Home base — stability, coherence, and the foundation of all harmony. No accidentals needed.

BLUE

SECONDARY DOMINANT

Non-diatonic dominant chords. Each contains a tritone pointing at a specific diatonic target. V7/[target] — creates brief tonicization and directed forward momentum.

RED

MODAL INTERCHANGE

Borrowed from parallel modes (same root, different scale). Creates emotional contrast and depth — the "darkness dial" — without leaving the key center.

Sample 9-Chord Progression in C Major — Color-Coded

Cmaj7
I — TONIC

Am7
VI — TONIC

Dm7
II — SUB

G7
V7 — DOM

E7
V7/VI — BLUE

Am7
VI — TONIC

Fm7
IV- — RED

Bb7
bVII7 — RED

Cmaj7
I — TONIC

Green = Diatonic (home base) Blue = Secondary Dominant (tonicization) Red = Modal Interchange (borrowed)

REAL SONGS — THE COLOR SYSTEM APPLIED

MOSTLY GREEN

"I'm Yours"

Jason Mraz

Almost entirely diatonic. The bright, simple, singable character comes from staying in pure Green territory. One Blue chord (secondary dominant) adds brief color.

I

V

vi

V7/V

IV

HEAVY RED

"Kiss from a Rose"

Seal

Extensively uses bVI, bVII — borrowed from parallel minor. The lush, cinematic, timeless quality comes from heavy Red borrowing creating constant emotional contrast against the major tonic.

bVI

bVII

I

iv

MIXED GREEN + RED

"Diary"

Alicia Keys

Alternates between diatonic Green stability and borrowed Red chords for emotional depth. The contrast between the bright sections and the darker borrowed moments creates the emotional arc.

I

vi

iv

V

"~95% of all Western harmony uses only these 3 categories. You don't need infinite complexity — you need to deeply understand Green, Blue, and Red, and when to use each one."